

Melissa Clark's Best Buttermilk Pancakes

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Julia Gartland for The New York Times. Food Stylist: Monica Pierini.

Ready In 25 min

Rating ★★★★★ (13)

The perfect pancakes have crisp edges, fluffy centers and are easy enough to cook when you're not fully caffeinated. This recipe hits all the right notes and features buttermilk for tang, a combination of baking soda and powder for lightness and a touch of honey or sugar for gentle sweetness and color. Just be sure to let the batter rest for at least 10 minutes before frying, which helps hydrate the flour and thicken the mixture, so the pancakes don't run all over the pan when you pour in the batter. Serve them hot with plenty of salted butter and maple syrup, if you like, for a classic breakfast that everyone loves.

INGREDIENTS

Yield: 4 to 6 servings

2 cups/250 grams all-purpose flour
(see Tips)

2 teaspoons baking powder

1 teaspoon baking soda

1 teaspoon fine sea or table salt

2 large eggs

1 tablespoon honey or sugar

2 cups/450 grams buttermilk (see
Tips for substitutes)

6 tablespoons/85 grams unsalted
butter, melted and cooled, plus
more for frying

1 teaspoon vanilla extract or finely

PREPARATION

Step 1

If you want to keep the pancakes warm until you're done cooking them all, heat the oven to 200 degrees. (Alternatively, serve them as you fry them).

Step 2

In a large bowl, whisk together the flour, baking powder, baking soda and salt.

Step 3

In a separate bowl, whisk together the eggs and honey (or sugar) until well combined, then whisk in buttermilk, melted butter and vanilla or zest, if using. Pour the buttermilk mixture into the flour mixture and stir gently using a wooden spoon until just combined. A few lumps are OK; they will dissolve by the time you fry the pancakes. Let the mixture rest at room temperature for at least 10

grated citrus zest (optional)

Neutral oil, such as grapeseed,
sunflower or avocado, for frying

Salted butter and maple syrup, for
serving

Optional mix-ins: Fresh fruit
(blueberries, sliced strawberries,
sliced bananas and diced peaches);
chocolate or butterscotch chips;
dried fruit (such as cherries);
chopped nuts; sprinkles; shredded
coconut; poppy or sesame seeds

pancakes. Let the mixture rest at room temperature for at least 10
minutes and up to 30 minutes before cooking (see Tips).

Step 4

Heat a skillet or griddle over medium-high until a drop of water
sizzles right away, about 30 seconds (see Tips). Add a drizzle of
oil to the pan and a little butter and let the butter melt into the oil,
which will keep the butter from burning. There should be a very
thin layer of fat, deep enough to swirl when you tilt the pan. When
the foam from the butter subsides, about 1 minute, pour $\frac{1}{3}$ cup of
batter into the pan to form pancakes, leaving space between each
one.

Step 5

Cook the pancakes until bubbles form all over the surface and the
edges begin to set, 2 to 3 minutes. Sprinkle pancakes lightly with
any mix-ins if using. Flip and cook until golden, 1 to 2 minutes
more.

Step 6

Serve finished pancakes immediately, or transfer to an oven-safe
platter or baking sheet and keep warm in the oven until you've
finished making all the pancakes. Continue frying pancakes,
adding oil and butter to the pan in between each batch as needed.
Serve with more butter, if you like, and syrup.

TIPS

*Substitute up to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup/90 grams whole wheat, spelt, rye or oat
flour (or $\frac{3}{4}$ cup/65 grams oatmeal) for the all-purpose flour. You
can also use $\frac{3}{4}$ cup/110 grams polenta or cornmeal; a coarse grind
gives a crunchy texture; finely ground meal makes these cakier.*

*You need something acidic to react with the baking soda and make
the pancakes rise (in addition to the baking powder, which is what
helps make these so very fluffy). Buttermilk, or sour cream or
yogurt thinned with some milk will do the trick, but if you don't
have any, spike 2 cups of regular whole milk with 2 tablespoons of
lemon juice or mild vinegar (rice vinegar or white wine work well).*

*Letting the pancake batter rest for 10 minutes to up to 30 minutes
at room temperature gives the flour time to absorb all the liquid.
Don't rush it! Otherwise, the pancakes may be too thin. You can
refrigerate the batter without the baking powder and soda mixed
in for up to 2 days. Stir them in 10 minutes before cooking. Note
that cold batter will need an extra minute or two in the pan to cook
through.*

Using a nonstick skillet makes pancakes easy to flip, but cast iron, carbon steel or stainless steel gives them more crispness at the edges.

Private Notes

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